

talkcan

A PROGRAMMABLE WALKIE-TALKIE FOR YOUR TOOLS

BRAND GUIDELINES

Strategy, identity, language, and product expression

Working direction • Version 0.1 • July 2026



Brand at a glance

The decisions that should remain stable while the product, integrations, and hardware evolve.



"Talk into the can. Reach anything on the other end."

The Talkcan brand idea

The short version

Name

Talkcan — written as one word, with a capital T in prose and lowercase in handles.

Category

A programmable walkie-talkie for tools, automations, services, people, and AI.

Promise

The fastest, most natural path from a spoken thought to the right destination.

Personality

Resourceful, friendly, direct, curious, and quietly capable.

Primary descriptor

A programmable walkie-talkie for your tools.

Use this directly beneath the name when the audience does not yet know what Talkcan is.

Brand principle

Talkcan should make sophisticated voice routing feel as approachable as two cans joined by a string. The product may be technically deep; the brand should never make people feel that they need to be.

01 / BRAND SYSTEM

Brand foundation

Why Talkcan exists, what it promises, and what it refuses to become.

Product thesis

Talkcan is a radio of configurable channels for voice tools. It gives one physical or on-screen push-to-talk interface many possible destinations: a recorder, transcript, webhook, automation, service, assistant, or any other user-defined route.

Mission

Make voice a practical interface for everything.

Talkcan removes the friction between having a thought and sending it to the right place.

Vision

A world where people can speak to their digital tools without stopping what they are doing, finding an app, navigating a menu, or staring at a screen.

Brand promise

Hold, talk, release. Talkcan takes care of the route.

Non-negotiable product truths

- Voice is the primary input, not an afterthought added to a chat interface.
- Channels are the primary organizing model.
- The interaction must remain predictable and eyes-free once configured.
- AI is one possible destination—not the definition of the product.
- Asynchronous conversations, backlogs, replay, and history are first-class behaviors.
- The screen supports operation; it should not dominate the live interaction.

02 / BRAND SYSTEM

Positioning

The mental category Talkcan should own and the alternatives it should contrast against.



Positioning statement

For people who want to use voice while their hands and eyes are busy, Talkcan is an open, programmable walkie-talkie that routes each spoken message to the right tool or conversation. Unlike voice assistants tied to one vendor or app, Talkcan lets the user decide what every channel does.

Primary audiences

Makers & developers

People building personal automations, local agents, integrations, and unusual hardware workflows.

Hands-busy users

Drivers, cyclists, field workers, cooks, technicians, and anyone who cannot comfortably navigate a screen.

Voice-first organizers

People capturing notes, logs, reminders, and ideas throughout the day.

Open-source contributors

People who want a composable voice platform rather than a closed assistant ecosystem.

Competitive frame

DO

A configurable radio with many channels

A user-owned routing layer

A hardware-friendly interaction model

A platform for tools and conversations

DON'T

Another general-purpose chat app

A single AI assistant with a microphone

A voice remote for one proprietary service

A novelty push-to-talk recorder

03 / BRAND SYSTEM

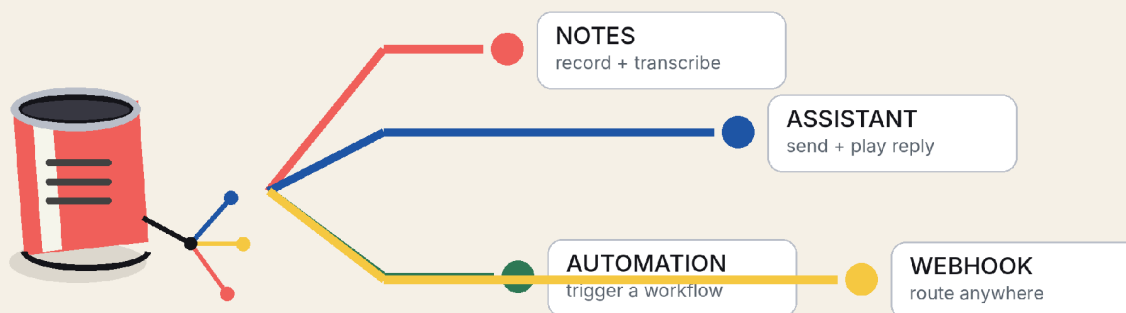
The Talkcan story

A familiar physical metaphor for a flexible digital system.



One can. Many strings.

Your voice is the input. Each channel decides what happens next.



The metaphor

A tin-can telephone is immediate, understandable, and a little magical: speak into one end and your voice appears somewhere else. Talkcan preserves that simplicity while replacing the single string with configurable channels.

What each element means

The can

The user's microphone, speaker, and push-to-talk control.

The string

A selected channel and its routing pipeline.

The other end

A person, log, service, automation, webhook, or assistant.

The knot

Configuration: the rules that bind voice to an outcome.

Useful contrast

The brand can look playful because the product behavior must feel dependable. Friendly on the outside; deterministic underneath.

04 / BRAND SYSTEM

Personality

The human qualities that should be recognizable in every message, interface, and contribution.



Resourceful

Talkcan feels homemade in the best sense: adaptable, repairable, and built to do real work.

Friendly

It speaks plainly, welcomes experimentation, and never performs technical superiority.

Direct

Instructions and status messages are short enough to understand while moving.

Curious

The brand encourages people to connect strange, useful, and personal things.

Quietly capable

Humor is present, but reliability is the punchline—not a secondary concern.

User-owned

The user chooses the channels, providers, endpoints, storage, and level of complexity.

Personality sliders

Playful

Serious



Handmade

Corporate



Direct

Elaborate



Technical

Magical



Playful

Serious



Calm

Energetic



Opinionated

Neutral



Voice and tone

How Talkcan sounds when it explains, guides, celebrates, warns, and fails.

Voice rules

- 1 Use ordinary words before technical vocabulary. Explain the mechanism only when it helps someone act.
- 2 Lead with the state or action. The user may be listening rather than reading.
- 3 Keep the humor dry and optional. Never joke while reporting data loss, permission failure, or safety-critical states.
- 4 Write like a capable project maintainer: honest about limitations, specific about next steps, and allergic to hype.
- 5 Say "channel," "message," "talk," "listen," and "route." Avoid turning every feature into an AI metaphor.

Do and don't

DO

"Assistant selected. 3 messages waiting."

"Couldn't reach the webhook. Your recording is saved."

"Hold PTT, talk, then release."

"This channel sends transcripts to your endpoint."

DON'T

"Your omnichannel experience is now activated."

"Oopsie! The internet ate your message."

"Leverage the PTT interaction paradigm."

"Harness AI-powered conversational synergies."

05 / VOICE AND TONE / CONTINUED

Tone by situation

Situation	Tone	Example
Onboarding	Warm and concrete	"Let's connect your talk button."
Normal operation	Minimal and calm	"Notes selected."
Success	Brief and satisfying	"Sent."
Recoverable error	Reassuring and actionable	"Offline. Recording saved for later."
Destructive action	Unambiguous and sober	"Delete this channel and its local history?"
Contributor docs	Friendly and precise	"Adapters translate Talkcan messages into service-specific requests."

Microcopy patterns

State + next step "Offline. Recording saved for later."	Object + count "Assistant. 3 messages waiting."
Action + destination "Sending to Notes..."	Problem + recovery "Couldn't connect. Try again or keep this recording."

06 / BRAND SYSTEM

Messaging system

A compact set of reusable language for GitHub, app stores, presentations, and launch materials.



Primary message hierarchy

NAME Talkcan
DESCRIPTOR A programmable walkie-talkie for your tools.
ONE-LINE EXPLANATION Choose a channel, hold to talk, and route your voice to a recorder, automation, service, assistant, or anything else you configure.

Elevator pitch

Talkcan turns a push-to-talk device into a voice interface for everything. Each channel can record, transcribe, automate, call a webhook, talk to an assistant, or connect to another service. Once configured, the essential loop works without looking at the phone: choose a channel, hold, talk, and listen.

Tagline bank

- Talk into the can.
- One button. Any channel.
- Your voice, on the right string.
- Push to talk to your tools.
- Whatever's on the other end.
- A little radio for everything.

Recommended pairing

Use "Talk into the can." for personality-led surfaces. Use "A programmable walkie-talkie for your tools." when comprehension matters more than charm.

Naming and nomenclature

How the brand appears in prose, code, repositories, packages, and future product architecture.

Canonical casing

Surface	Form	Guidance
Brand in prose	Talkcan	Talkcan routes your voice to configurable channels.
Logo wordmark	talkcan	Lowercase is a visual treatment, not the prose casing.
GitHub organization	talkcan	github.com/talkcan
Main repository	talkcan/talkcan	Use the simplest discoverable default.
CLI command	talkcan	Lowercase command.
Daemon	talkcand	Only if a background service is introduced.
Environment variables	TALKCAN_*	Uppercase with underscores.

Suggested repository family

talkcan/talkcan
 talkcan/talkcan-android
 talkcan/talkcan-core
 talkcan/talkcan-channels
 talkcan/talkcan-sdk
 talkcan/talkcan-docs

Product terms

- Channel — a user-visible route that determines what happens to a spoken message.
- Message — one complete push-to-talk capture or one playable inbound response.
- Active channel — the destination used by normal PTT.
- Priority channel — the destination available through the dedicated priority action.
- Pending message — an inbound message waiting to be heard.
- Adapter — implementation that connects a channel to an external system.

08 / BRAND SYSTEM

Logo system

A simple mark built from the can, the string, and the branching channel model.



Primary lockup on light



Reverse lockup on dark

Concept

The mark begins with one familiar tin can. Its string branches into several endpoints, representing the defining Talkcan behavior: one voice interface connected to many configurable channels.

Rules

- Use the full lockup whenever the audience may not recognize the symbol.
- Use the symbol alone for app icons, favicons, avatars, and compact hardware labels.
- Maintain clear space equal to the height of the can's top rim on every side.
- Do not place the full lockup below 32 mm wide in print or 160 px wide on screen.
- Use the monochrome mark when production constraints prevent the full palette.

Avoid

DO

Keep the can upright enough to remain recognizable.

Use approved palette colors or a single solid color.

Preserve the relationship between symbol and wordmark.

DON'T

Do not add metallic gradients, bevels, or photorealistic texture.

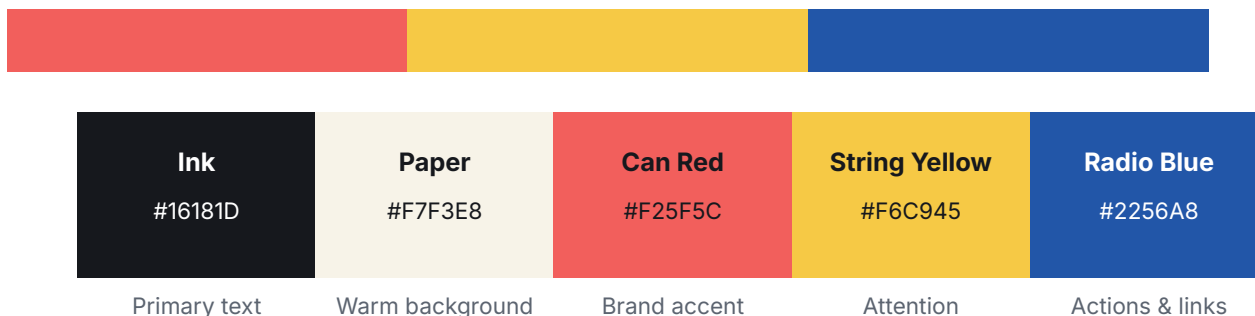
Do not replace the string endpoints with service logos inside the primary mark.

Do not write the brand as TalkCan in normal use.

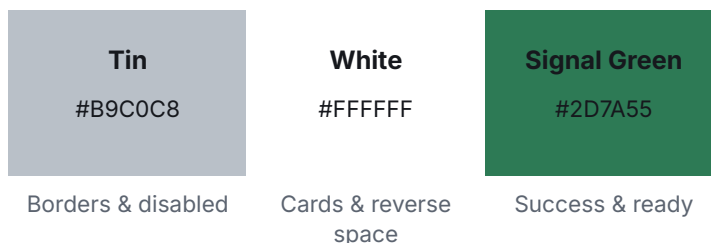
09 / BRAND SYSTEM

Color

A warm utility palette: familiar materials, clear signals, and enough contrast for real operational interfaces.



Supporting neutral



Accessibility guidance

- Ink on Paper: 16.0:1 — suitable for all text sizes.
- White on Radio Blue: 7.1:1 — suitable for normal text and controls.
- Ink on String Yellow: 11.3:1 — suitable for notices and highlighted text.
- White on Can Red: 3.2:1 — do not use for small body text. Prefer Ink or use red as a non-text accent.
- Never communicate connection, recording, unread, or error state by color alone.

Color behavior

The palette should feel tactile and slightly nostalgic, but interfaces must remain crisp. Use Paper and White generously; reserve the bright colors for signal, hierarchy, and delight.

Typography

Readable at a glance, friendly at display sizes, and practical across Android, GitHub, documentation, and the web.



Primary family — Inter

Talk into the can.

Channel selected. Two messages waiting.

```
talkcan channel add webhook --name garage
```

Roles

Role	Typeface	Use
Display	Inter Display ExtraBold	Wordmark-adjacent headlines and campaign statements.
Interface	Inter Regular / Medium / Bold	UI, documentation, body copy, and labels.
Code	Liberation Mono or system monospace	Commands, configuration, package names, and technical examples.

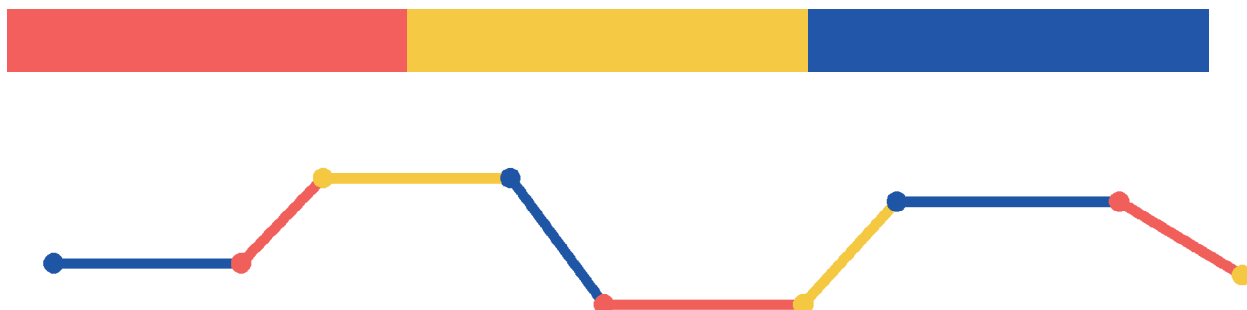
Writing style

- Prefer sentence case. Avoid title case for every interface label.
- Keep operational labels short: "Ready," "Recording," "Sending," "Waiting."
- Use numerals for message counts and channel positions.
- Avoid excessive punctuation and all-caps except short status labels or environment variables.

11 / BRAND SYSTEM

Graphic language

A flexible visual toolkit derived from strings, knots, nodes, channels, and low-tech communication objects.



Core devices

Strings

Use lines to connect ideas, show routes, divide sections, and guide the eye through a sequence.

Nodes

Small circles represent channel endpoints, queued messages, or integration points.

Cans

Use simplified illustrations as anchors, mascots, empty states, and onboarding moments.

Labels

Borrow from practical equipment: stamped names, numbered channels, compact status tags.

Illustration style

- Flat shapes with a small amount of hand-drawn imperfection.
- Bold silhouettes that remain legible at small sizes.
- No glossy 3D renders or generic AI-generated futurism.
- Show real use contexts: walking, driving, repairing, cooking, building, and experimenting.
- Represent services as endpoints on a route, not as magical clouds surrounding the user.

Photography

When photography is used, favor candid, practical environments and visible hands-on interaction. Show the PTT device, phone, workshop, dashboard, bicycle, car, kitchen, or field setting. Avoid staged headset-call-center imagery and glowing humanoid AI motifs.

Product expression

How the brand becomes interface behavior, audio feedback, microcopy, and everyday operational confidence.

Interface principles

- 1 Glanceable: the active channel and current state should be obvious from arm's length.
- 2 Calm: avoid animated noise while recording, waiting, or playing messages.
- 3 Stateful: show what Talkcan is doing now, what happened, and what will happen next.
- 4 Forgiving: preserve recordings through network failure whenever technically possible.
- 5 Hardware-consistent: on-screen controls should reinforce the physical control model, not invent a competing one.

State language

Internal state	User-facing label	Meaning
Ready	Ready	The selected channel can accept a message.
Capturing	Recording...	The button is held and audio is being captured.
Routing	Sending...	The message is leaving the device.
Queued	Saved for later	Delivery will resume when possible.
Listening	Playing 2 of 3	An inbound message is being heard.
Unread	3 waiting	The channel has pending messages.

Sound identity

- Use short, dry sounds inspired by switches, soft clicks, and radio confirmation tones.
- A channel-change sound should be distinct from send, receive, error, and playback-complete sounds.
- Spoken announcements should be concise: channel name first, then message count or state.
- Avoid nostalgic radio static when it could be mistaken for connection failure or poor audio quality.

Ready-to-use applications

Copy and conventions for the first public surfaces of the project.

GitHub organization

DISPLAY NAME

Talkcan

DESCRIPTION

A programmable walkie-talkie for routing voice to tools, automations, services, and AI through configurable channels.

README opening

Talkcan is a hardware-first, voice-first channel router. Choose a channel, hold push-to-talk, speak, and let that channel decide what happens—record it, transcribe it, trigger an automation, call a webhook, or play a response.

Short social bio

BIO

Open-source programmable walkie-talkie for your tools. Pick a channel. Hold to talk. Route your voice anywhere.

App-store direction

TITLE
Talkcan
SUBTITLE
Programmable voice channels
OPENING
Turn a push-to-talk button into a voice interface for notes, automations, webhooks, assistants, and more.

13 / READY-TO-USE APPLICATIONS / CONTINUED

Launch headline ideas

- Meet Talkcan: a walkie-talkie for your tools.
- Talk into the can. Route your voice anywhere.
- One talk button. As many channels as you can build.
- Your automations are now on channel three.

Contributor and community copy

ISSUE PROMPT
What did you expect to hear or happen? What happened instead?
RELEASE-NOTE OPENER
This release adds two new strings to the can: local transcription and queued webhook delivery.
COMPATIBILITY LABEL
Works with Talkcan
HARDWARE STICKER
HOLD • TALK • RELEASE
"Built in public. Easy to extend. Clear about what is official."
Community principle

Accessibility and inclusion

The brand promise depends on usability without sight, precise touch, or continuous attention.

Required practices

- All core actions must have spoken or tonal confirmation that does not depend on seeing the screen.
- Do not rely on color alone for recording, playback, unread, error, or connection states.
- Support scalable type and preserve hierarchy at larger Android font settings.
- Use plain language and avoid humor in critical errors or destructive confirmations.
- Make channel names user-defined and announce them before pending-message counts.
- Provide transcripts when available, while keeping audio as a first-class message format.
- Design for one-handed and eyes-free use without assuming perfect hearing or speech.

Inclusive language

DO	DON'T
"Talk button" or "push-to-talk button"	"Normal users" versus "advanced users"
"Couldn't understand that recording"	"You spoke incorrectly"
"Connect an account or endpoint"	"Simply connect..." when setup is complex
"Choose the channel you want"	Gendered assumptions about assistants or voices

Governance and rollout

What to secure, publish, and standardize before the brand becomes difficult to change.

Immediate checklist

- 1 Reserve the GitHub organization and primary repository under the lowercase handle talkcan.
- 2 Choose and register the primary domain and defensive high-value variants.
- 3 Run professional trademark clearance in the intended launch markets, including adjacent "Tin Can" communications products.
- 4 Create final vector artwork for the symbol, wordmark, monochrome variants, and app icon.
- 5 Publish the canonical one-line description in the GitHub organization, README, website metadata, and app manifest.
- 6 Create a small brand-assets repository containing SVG, PNG, color tokens, typography guidance, and license terms.
- 7 Document naming rules for official integrations and community projects.

Brand ownership rules

- Official projects use the Talkcan name directly and follow these guidelines.
- Community projects should use "for Talkcan," "Talkcan-compatible," or "Unofficial Talkcan..." rather than implying endorsement.
- The code license and trademark policy should be separate documents.
- Major changes to the name, symbol, or core descriptor should be recorded as project decisions.

Status of this document

This is a working brand direction, not a legal clearance or a finished production identity. The strategy and verbal system are ready to use; the logo artwork and name should receive final design and trademark review before commercial launch.

Talk into the can.

The system can be powerful. The interaction should remain simple.



"One voice interface. Many channels. Whatever you put on the other end."

Talkcan

Canonical summary

NAME
Talkcan
DESCRIPTOR
A programmable walkie-talkie for your tools.
BRAND LINE
Talk into the can.
GITHUB DESCRIPTION
A programmable walkie-talkie for routing voice to tools, automations, services, and AI through configurable channels.